Spoonface Steinberg

By Lee Hall

SPOONFACE: **(Pg 3)** I was never right ever since I was born - this means that I do very bad writing and that I can't speak proper and that I am backwards and that I am a special child - but ***why*** is a mystery for what they have not got an answer - I was in the hospital and when Mam looked at my face she noticed that it was round - and everyone came and looked at my face - and they laughed and said I was Spoonface because my face it was round as a spoon and when you look into a spoon you see this face just like mine- and that is how I came to be Spoonface Steinberg…

INTRODUCTION

"Out of the mouths of babes" -- In this selection, a special child confronts her impending death with stoical grace and with a belief in the glory of God. She speaks of loss, separation, sparks and death with a sense of innocent, baffled wonderment. May it help you find your own "spark."

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SPOONFACE: **(Pg 5)** I think I was always backwards ever since I was born - but nobody knows for sure - all the experts with all their computers and all the doctors who poke in your ear and look into your brain and all the people who do the quizzes and all questioners and such like - they all said no one can know can ever know for certain. *(beat)* I cannot go to a proper school as I am not allowed on account of my brain - but I am quite a special little girl, though.

(Pg 6) I believe that I was supposed to be backward - I believe it was all part of what is supposed to be - and when I was born God came and touched me on my head - and made me me.

One day I started to do the numbers. Dad came back from the university and he was with a calculator for doing the marks. He was sat doing the marks when he said two numbers

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and I went 42- because it was the answer of the two numbers - and then he goes - goodness me - and then he said two more numbers and I said 147- which was another answer- and then he **(Pg 7)** did more and more - and some of the answers he had to do on the calculator - and then he started shouting of Mam - and Mam came running as if there was something bad - but it was only me doing the numbers and I did more and more and Mam kissed me and was crying and Dad was laughing- and Mam said he had to stop- and I said what was it that had made her cry?- and she said that it was because of the numbers and never in the world did they know I could do the numbers - but I could do them now- and I was a genius - and it was of my brain.

And then I had to do them in front of a doctor - and then the doctor said - if Spoonface can do numbers then she can do dates - and then I did some - this is how I do it- what is the day of July the 4th 2010? - Saturday - amazing, absolutely amazing- and that is how I do the dates and they have to look it up in a book as soon as I've said the answer and there it is - and they say how do I know so many numbers? and I say I don't know- and how do I know so many dates? - and I also say I don't know - but it's just obvious like colours and that is why. **(Pg 8)** So this is all because I am autistic. *(long beat)*

(Pg 9-10) When I first started feeling funny that is when I still had hair - there was hardly nothing wrong except I was tired a bit - but then Mam was very worried that I was thinner and thinner and one day I might fade away to a speck - and that I was looking peaky - but because I'm backwards then I wasn't very good at saying what is wrong- so she took me straight to the doctor in case I disappeared- and the doctor looked at me like this *(makes a serious face)* ... and he said - 'Oh deary me, Spoonface will have to go straight to the hospital' - which is where I went. They were all very nice to me and the doctors held on to my hand and they all smiled which means something is wrong – **(Pg 11)** The doctor said that I was going to die. only they said there was hope - that there was always hope - and anyway, it would take a long time for me to die so we went home for some tea - and Mam said that even if I **(Pg 12)** was supposed to die there would still be hope 'cos there was

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millions of people that were saved by God everyday - so it was better not be too worried about it- so I said I wasn't worried and we had fish fingers.

(Pg 17-19) Doctor Bernstein said that I should be very brave because when his Mam was little she was very brave as well even though she was in a concentration camp. Concentration camps were these places where they took Jewish people to burn - this is what the doctor said - he said that there were loads of people and they all had to sleep on one bunk and that- and the Nazis shot them and then they starved them and it was horrible for his poor Mam because she was just little - in the whole history of the world there has never been anything as awful as the concentration camps, but what happened to the poor people there was to show that they never gave up hope - and that never mind the worse thing that could happen to people they could not stop them from being human beings - some of the little children were skinnier than I am now with the cancer, and all that was wrong with them was they didn't eat just this soup what didn't have any vegetables in it - and they'd just be standing there and their Mammies and Daddies would be bashed - like there was one little girl who was with her Mam and the soldier came and hit her Mam on the head and shot her and then she died and the poor little girl just had to stand there - that little girl was the Mam of the doctor- and there were millions and millions of people like this - so in comparison to me it is much worse- and I felt sorry for the doctor when he told me these things as he had a little cry in the corner of his eye- and he never said any of this to scare me he said all of this to help me because the whole lesson of the stories was that little children were braver than everybody else this was the lesson - that no matter how bad it is for us while we are dying it is still a wonderful thing that we are alive –

This is what the doctor said- and he said when the soldiers came and took the poor little children to the ovens and the poor children and everything thought they were going for a wash but everybody knew really that they were going to get gassed - because they had seen the smoke of burning bodies - then the children were waiting outside and all the

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little children wrote things on the walls - on the walls of the gas chamber where they were about to be cooked. And some little children wrote poems- and some little children drew pictures- and even today you can see the pictures of butterflies on the outside - little butterflies that were flying up to God - beautiful butterflies with tender wings that would brush their faces and kiss them better before they flew careful little butterflies in all the death and the mud and everything- and that day when he told me this I cried for the butterflies and the little children - and all their sad faces drifting up to heaven.

(Pg 22) I started getting even worse than I was- really woozy and everything - this time they said they would give me this special thing in my arm and that would make me sick and have diarrhea and all my hair would fall out – **(Pg 23)** and every day I was sicker and sicker and I goes to God - Please God, why are you making me so sickly? - and I never found out because he never said - then I was quite depressed - and my eyebrows fell out. **(Pg 24)** The good news was that my hair would grow- but the bad news was I was still full of cancer and there was nothing to be done - all the chemicals and everything was useless.

(Pg 25) And when we went home the doctor gave me this book to me- but I can't read so I had to get Mam to read it to me- and then I found all this stuff out - like you had to pray to God - and that this would help get on his good side and even if you did die then he'd look out for you afterwards - **(Pg 26)** [See] when the world was made, God made it out of magic sparks - everything that there is, was all made of magic sparks and the whole point of being alive - the whole point of living is to find the spark- **(Pg 28-29)** if only you could see the spark then there was a meaning - because what was the meaning of anything? - if you were going to die, what was the meaning? *(thoughtfully)* The meaning was if you found the spark - then it would be like electricity - and you would glow like a light and you would shine like the sparks and that was the meaning it wasn't like an answer or a number or any such - it was glowing- it was finding the sparks inside you and setting them free.

And the meaning wasn't that I was going to die but that I was still alive- and I could make

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everybody shine and I thought, if I wasn't scared of when I wasn't born why would I be scared of when I wasn't existed at the other end- you can't feel the end or touch the end- 'cos it was just nothing- the end of things is not the problem 'cos there was really no ends to find - that was the meaning there are no real ends- only middles, and even if I was at the end I was still in the middle - 'cos it wouldn't know it was the end then - because it would be ended - so everything is in the middle - even if it was at the middle of an end - it didn't matter because I'm in it. In the middle of the middle was sparks - the sparks what would save me- the sparks what I could make shine - the sparks that knew there was no more endings - the sparks what would be as a huge light in the world and the sparks would fly up and take me to heaven.

(Pg 33-34) Sometimes it is scary - but to think that I'll not ***be*** is impossible because I'm here- and when I'm not here there'll still be radios and beaches and sunshine and walks in the rain and films and music and my Mam and Dad and flowers. - and there isn't even a hole somewhere where I used to be - and apart from people what remember me and what I was like there is nothing missing from when I was here - there is no space in the universe where people have dropped out- it is all filled in as full as ever.

(Pg 29) [See] the sparks? The sparks . . . fly up and take me to heaven.

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier - MS
2019 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier – MS
2023 National Qualifier – MS
2024 National Qualifier – MS
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